

SOUTH AFRICA

Comprehensive Model UN Research Dossier – South Africa

◆ Key Country Details Table

Detail	Information
Full Name	Republic of South Africa
Short Form	South Africa
Capital	Pretoria (administrative), Bloemfontein (judicial), Cape Town (legislative)
Region (UN)	Africa
Government Type	Parliamentary republic
Head of State	Cyril Ramaphosa, President
Head of Government	Cyril Ramaphosa, President
Currency	South African Rand (ZAR)
UN Member Since	1945 (re-admitted in 1994 after apartheid)
MUN Standing	Influential Global South voice; prominent in BRICS, peacekeeping, and African diplomacy. Often acts as a bridge between developed and developing nations.

General Book Recommendations

1. **"Foreign Policy in Post-Apartheid South Africa"** – John Siko
2. **"South Africa and the United Nations"** – Peter Vale
3. **"BRICS and Africa: Emerging Markets and South-South Cooperation"** – Francis Kornegay & Narnia Bohler-Muller

4. **"The Diplomacy of Liberation: The Foreign Relations of the ANC Since 1960"**
– Scott Thomas
5. **"South Africa's Multilateral Diplomacy and Global Change"** – Maxi Schoeman

South Africa: UNHRC and Human Rights Resources

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
OHCHR – South Africa Country Page	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/south-africa	Official human rights obligations and reviews
UPR Info – South Africa	https://www.upr-info.org/en/review/South-Africa	Reviews of SA's human rights performance
Amnesty International – South Africa	https://www.amnesty.org/en/location/africa/southern-africa/south-africa/	Reports on protest policing, migration, GBV
Human Rights Watch – SA	https://www.hrw.org/africa/south-africa	Reports on justice, rights, and abuses
UN Treaty Body Database – SA Reports	https://tbinternet.ohchr.org/	UN treaty compliance documentation
Freedom House – South Africa	https://freedomhouse.org/country/south-africa/freedom-world/2023	Civil liberties and press freedom rankings
SAHRC Reports on Xenophobia	https://www.sahrc.org.za/	State action against attacks on foreigners
UNHRC Sessions – SA Statements	https://webtv.un.org/	Debates, condemnations, and speeches by SA reps

Parliamentary Monitoring Group – Human Rights Hearings	https://pmg.org.za/	Tracking legislation and human rights debates
African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights	https://achpr.au.int/	Continental rights enforcement body
South African Litigation Centre (SALC)	https://www.southernafricalitigationcentre.org/	Regional human rights cases and advocacy

Title	Link	Relevance
Universal Periodic Review - South Africa	Link	Provides an overview of South Africa's participation in the UPR process, including reports and recommendations.
South Africa's National Report to the UNHRC	Link	Details South Africa's self-assessment of its human rights situation and measures taken.
Compilation of UN Information - South Africa	Link	Summarizes information from UN entities on South Africa's human rights obligations and commitments.
Summary of Stakeholders' Information - South Africa	Link	Presents perspectives from NGOs and other stakeholders on South Africa's human rights situation.
Amnesty International Report on South Africa	Link	Analyzes key human rights issues in South Africa, including freedom of expression and assembly.
Human Rights Watch World Report 2024 - South Africa	Link	Highlights human rights developments in South Africa, focusing on political freedoms and justice.
Freedom House Report on South Africa	Link	Assesses South Africa's political rights and civil liberties, providing a comparative score.
OHCHR South Africa Country Page	Link	Offers comprehensive information on South Africa's human rights situation and OHCHR's work in the country.

Amnesty International: Human Rights Delayed	Link	Evaluates the implementation of recommendations made to South Africa in its previous UPR, including in relation to gender-based violence.
Human Rights Watch: Violence Against Children in South Africa	Link	Discusses the prevalence of violence against children and the need for government action.
Freedom House: Freedom on the Net 2024 - South Africa	Link	Assesses internet freedom in South Africa, highlighting challenges and improvements.
Amnesty International: Human Rights Defender's Life in Danger	Link	Details threats faced by human rights defender Nomsa Sizani.
Human Rights Watch: Government Failing Older People	Link	Highlights challenges faced by older people in South Africa, including inadequate housing and care.
Freedom House: Transnational Repression in South Africa	Link	Examines South Africa's role as a host country for refugees and the challenges of transnational repression.
Amnesty International: Human Rights Concerns in South Africa	Link	Calls on the government to ensure key rights protected under the Constitution.
Human Rights Watch: Toxic Rhetoric Endangers Migrants	Link	Discusses xenophobic violence and the need for government action.
Freedom House: Country Profile - South Africa	Link	Provides an overview of South Africa's political rights and civil liberties.
Amnesty International: Continued Violence and Looting	Link	Addresses the unrest in South Africa and the failures of the criminal justice system.
Human Rights Watch: World Report 2025 - South Africa	Link	Provides an updated overview of human rights issues in South Africa.
Freedom House: Freedom in the World 2025 - South Africa	Link	Offers the latest assessment of South Africa's political rights and civil liberties.

OHCHR: Universal Periodic Review Fourth Cycle - South Africa	Link	Contains reference documents for South Africa's fourth UPR cycle.
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Unique Aspects of South Africa's Engagement with UNHRC

- **Post-Apartheid Human Rights Framework:** South Africa's journey from apartheid to democracy has been a significant one, characterized by a strong commitment to building a solid human rights framework. This is evident in a constitution that firmly establishes a range of rights and freedoms for its citizens.
- **Gender-Based Violence:** Even with legal protections in place, gender-based violence continues to be a major problem, marked by alarming rates of sexual offenses and femicide.
- **Xenophobia and Migrant Rights:** The country has faced recurring incidents of xenophobic violence that have targeted migrants and refugees, sparking serious worries about their rights and safety.
- **Freedom of Expression:** Even though the constitution promises freedom of expression, we've seen troubling cases where journalists and human rights defenders have faced threats and violence.
- **Internet Freedom:** South Africa usually enjoys a good level of internet freedom, but there are still some hurdles to overcome, like worries about surveillance and the rise of misinformation.
- **Elderly and Children's Rights:** Reports emphasize the urgent need for better care and protection for our older adults and children, especially when it comes to preventing abuse and ensuring they have access to essential services.